



Photographs ANI

from Lalkuan by 17,527 votes to the BJP's Mohan Bisht. The Congress, which initially seemed well-placed for a return to power, proved to be more adept in the art of fratricide. Lalkuan was just one of the 29 seats where the Congress faced rebels. Perhaps the party leadership was distracted by the unfounded near-certainty that the BJP couldn't stave off anti-incumbency.

This time, the open fight among Congress leaders allowed the BJP the time to not only regroup but also to trumpet the familiar tropes of Hindutva, development and nationalism. The party also managed to hardsell PM Narendra Modi's emotional connection with the 'Char Dham', despite campaign restrictions that limited him to only three physical rallies—at Srinagar, Almora and Rudrapur.

The PM's iconic stature among the Hindutva ranks also helped smooth over internal disputes in the party. Trivendra Rawat had prised open a fault-line during his stint as chief minister by mooting legislation to hand administrative control of the Char Dham—Kedarnath, Badrinath, Gangotri and Yamunotri—besides 49 other temples to a Devasthanam Management Board. The protests started with local temple priests, spread to the VHP (Vishva Hindu Parishad) and Trivendra's old buddies in the RSS, and inevitably reached the state assembly. The Dhami regime too had to risk the wrath of the Hindutva hardliners when, on instructions from the Prime Minister's Office (PMO), he finally cracked down on the hate speech of Yati Narsinghanand Saraswati and his cohorts at the Haridwar Dharam Sansad.

However, the BJP campaign did not shy away from Hindutva sentiments and hypernationalism. The party also referenced the late chief of defence staff Bipin Rawat (who died in a helicopter crash on December 8 last year), national security and the importance of the forces. This seems to have addressed the two hot-button topics in the hill state—army welfare (Uttarakhand is a major recruitment zone) and religious tourism at the Char Dham, a mainstay of the state economy. Meanwhile, the BJP stoked communal prejudices by playing up a video of Congress leader Aqeel Ahmed quoting a commitment by Harish Rawat to set up a 'Muslim University'. Muslims make up about 14 per cent of the state's electorate and are largely concentrated in Haridwar district. The BJP got just three of the 11 assembly seats in the district.

The BSP commands some influence in Haridwar district and the Dalit-Muslim combination had won 7 per cent of the total votes in 2017, mostly in Haridwar, though without any seat to show for it. This time, their candidates won Laksar and Manglur seats.

There is another perennial faultline in Uttarakhand: the historic divide between the two hill divisions of Garhwal and Kumaon. Here too, Trivendra, as CM, had stirred a controversy by notifying Gairsain as a third hill division, with districts from both Garhwal and Kumaon. It meant the latter would have had to cede even its cultural capital, Almora. In the end, along with his ill-fated temple bill, this ensured he was practically escorted out of office with black flags.

Before going to the polls, Dhami, who is from the Kumaon, ensured that he got the prime minister himself to lay the foundation stones for 23 projects worth over Rs 17,500 crore in the state. On the anvil are multiple road-widening projects, a hydropower project in Dhami's own district of Pithoragarh, and a sewerage network upgrade in Nainital. While sounding productive, all this remains work in progress and will take time to bear fruit in terms of creating jobs.

Many of the younger voters were understandably worried about the economy and their seemingly vanishing job prospects. The incumbent CM's problem was that he had nothing much to show except promises. So he added a personal touch and tried to project himself as the head of a youth-oriented government. The narrative suited the BJP: the Congress's CM aspirant, Harish Rawat, is 73; the next in line, Pritam Singh, is 63. Uttarakhand's 7.9 million electorate had around 1.2 million new voters. Just months after Dhami took over last year, National Statistics Office (NSO) data

